horrible. *Thaniniram*, a paper known for its yellow journalism, had broken the story of Mariam's arrest and followed up it with stories linking her to ISRO.

Kerala Kaumudi, whose owner M S Mani had an axe to grind with inspector general of police Raman Srivastava, jumped into the bandwagon. Soon, virtually every Malayalam newspaper was competing with each other churning out 'exclusive' stories of spies, sex and rocketry—a deadly combination that would make any B-grade movie a super hit.

Most of the Malayalam newspaper stories exposed the reporters' total ignorance of technical matters (I did not expect a general reporter to know rocket science, but if you are writing about the subject, you should know the difference between a rocket and a satellite). But when it came to Mariam Rasheeda, they all claimed to know everything from her anatomy to her bedroom behaviours.

'Mariam, a tuna in bed,' screamed a front page headline of a mainstream Malayalam paper. The report was by a chief of bureau who usually stepped in to write only 'very important stories', leaving the mundane stuff to junior reporters. A budding cartoonist in a Malayalam magazine showed me in bed with a woman spy; the caption read, 'That's liquid propulsion!'

By and large the English newspapers and magazines refused to be carried away by the vernacular sensationalism; some of the papers like *The Indian Express* of the north and *India Today* even picked holes in the theory of Kerala Police and Intelligence Bureau. One the few exceptions was V K Madhavan Kutty, a senior journalist of the *The New Indian Express*, who gleefully bought the sugar-coated tales and fired away as if he was competing with the local giants Malayala *Manorama* and *Mathrubhumi*. This journalist, however, failed in his desperate attempts to get the rest of the English media to sing his tune.

VIKAS IS IN, I AM OUT

Once Brahm Prakash was convinced about the inevitability of incorporating a liquid engine into the PSLV configuration, things moved forward, but it was not as smooth as I wanted it to be.